

Albert Camus

FUNDAMENTALS

Albert Camus is often associated with existentialism, but he personally preferred to be identified with the philosophy of the absurd. His work delves into the inherent tension between humans' search for meaning and the apparent meaninglessness of the universe. Here are the primary themes associated with Camus' philosophy:

1. **The Absurd:** Central to Camus' thought is the concept of the absurd. The absurd arises from the confrontation between our desire for understanding and order and the apparent indifference and chaos of the universe. In other words, it's the clash between our search for meaning and the universe's seeming lack of it.
2. **Revolt:** Instead of succumbing to despair in the face of the absurd, Camus believed in revolting against it. This revolt doesn't mean an external rebellion but an internal, personal confrontation with the absurdity of existence. By recognising the absurd and choosing to continue living in spite of it, individuals assert their existence and dignity.
3. **Freedom:** For Camus, acknowledging the absurdity of life leads to a kind of freedom. Without predetermined meaning or destiny, individuals are free to create their own values and make their own choices.
4. **Passion:** In a universe devoid of true meaning or order, Camus argued for living with intensity and passion. Instead of retreating into despair or nihilism, he believed in embracing life's experiences fully.
5. **Acceptance:** While Camus emphasises revolt against the absurd, he also speaks of accepting the absurdity of life. This acceptance doesn't mean passive resignation but a conscious acknowledgment of life's inherent contradictions.
6. **Ethics of Ambiguity:** Similar to some other existentialists, Camus believed that in a universe without inherent moral order, individuals must navigate an ethical landscape filled with ambiguity. Without clear moral guidelines, individuals must make choices based on personal integrity and responsibility.
7. **Death:** The inevitability of death is a recurring theme in Camus' work. He viewed death as the ultimate absurdity, emphasising the tension it creates: individuals search for meaning in a life that is ultimately finite and transient.
8. **Nature and Beauty:** In his works, especially in novels like "The Stranger," Camus often alludes to the beauty of nature and the physical world. For Camus, nature's indifference contrasts with human emotion and passion, further highlighting the absurdity of existence.

It's worth noting that while Camus dealt with themes common to existentialism, such as freedom, alienation, and individualism, he had a unique perspective on these topics. His emphasis on the absurd and his ideas on how to confront it distinguish him from other existentialist thinkers.

Biography of Albert Camus:

1. **Early Life:** Albert Camus was born in Mondovi, Algeria, in 1913, when Algeria was a French colony. His father died during World War I, and Camus was raised in relative poverty by his mother in the Belcourt section of Algiers.
2. **Education:** Despite the challenges of his upbringing, Camus was a bright student. He attended the University of Algiers, where he studied philosophy and was influenced by thinkers like Friedrich Nietzsche and Søren Kierkegaard.
3. **Tuberculosis:** In his youth, Camus contracted tuberculosis, a disease that affected him intermittently throughout his life. His personal confrontation with illness and mortality had a profound impact on his philosophical perspectives, especially on themes related to the absurdity of life and death.
4. **World War II:** During World War II, Camus joined the French Resistance against the Nazi occupation and became an editor for the underground newspaper "Combat." His experiences during the war deepened his reflections on freedom, revolt, and the human capacity for both cruelty and nobility.
5. **Literary Career:** Camus became a prominent novelist, essayist, and playwright. His notable works include "The Stranger," "The Plague," "The Myth of Sisyphus," and "The Fall." Through his writings, he explored the themes of absurdity, alienation, and revolt.
6. **Death:** Camus died tragically in a car accident in 1960 at the age of 46.

Camus and Existentialism:

1. **Relationship with Sartre:** Initially, Camus had a close intellectual and personal relationship with Jean-Paul Sartre, another towering figure of existentialism. However, they later had a public falling out, primarily due to ideological differences, especially concerning the role of political violence and their views on the Soviet Union.
2. **Absurdist vs. Existentialist:** While Camus is often categorised with the existentialists, he saw himself more as an absurdist. The core of his philosophy revolved around the tension between the human quest for meaning and the inherent meaninglessness of the universe.

3. **Influence of Nietzsche and Kierkegaard:** Like many existentialists, Camus was influenced by Friedrich Nietzsche's critique of traditional values and Søren Kierkegaard's focus on individual existence and choice.

Camus Among Contemporaries:

1. **Philosophical Landscape:** Camus' contemporaries included existentialist thinkers like Jean-Paul Sartre, Simone de Beauvoir, and Maurice Merleau-Ponty. While Camus shared certain themes with these thinkers, his emphasis on the absurd set him apart.
2. **Literary Context:** As a writer, Camus was also part of the post-war literary world, which grappled with the traumas of World War II and the Holocaust. Writers like Samuel Beckett and Franz Kafka influenced and echoed Camus' themes of absurdity and alienation.

In summary, Albert Camus' life experiences, from his upbringing in colonial Algeria to his role in the French Resistance, deeply influenced his philosophical perspectives. While he shared the existentialist stage with giants like Sartre and de Beauvoir, his unique emphasis on the absurd and his skeptical approach to overarching ideologies distinguished him as a singular voice in 20th-century philosophy and literature.

Albert Camus' Philosophy:

1. **The Absurd:**
 - **Concept:** At the heart of Camus' philosophy is the notion of the absurd. It emerges from the clash between our human desire for meaning and the seemingly indifferent, chaotic universe. For Camus, the realisation of this incongruity is fundamental to human existence.
 - **Implication:** Accepting the absurd means recognising life's inherent lack of ultimate purpose or meaning. However, this acceptance should not lead to despair or nihilism.
 - **Ought:** Instead of succumbing to the weight of the absurd, one ought to confront it head-on, embracing life with passion and intensity.
2. **Revolt:**
 - **Concept:** Faced with the absurdity of existence, Camus advocates for revolt. This is not a physical rebellion but an internal, existential one—a consistent affirmation of life in the face of its inherent meaninglessness.
 - **Implication:** Revolt becomes a life-affirming act, a continuous challenge to the absurd, and a declaration of one's existence.

- **Ought:** Individuals ought to live authentically, fully embracing the human condition and its inherent contradictions. Through revolt, one can find personal freedom and agency.

3. **Freedom:**

- **Concept:** With the acknowledgment of life's absurdity comes a profound sense of freedom. In a universe devoid of preordained meaning or destiny, individuals are liberated to create their own values and paths.
- **Implication:** This freedom, however, is double-edged—it's both liberating and burdensome, as it places the responsibility of meaning-making squarely on the individual.
- **Ought:** Camus suggests that one ought to exercise this freedom responsibly and authentically, forging a path that resonates with one's personal truths.

4. **Ethics of Ambiguity:**

- **Concept:** In a world without inherent moral order, ethical decisions become complex. Camus acknowledges the inherent ambiguity in moral choices in an absurd universe.
- **Implication:** Traditional moral systems might fall short in providing clear guidance. Instead, moral decisions are deeply personal and often fraught with uncertainty.
- **Ought:** Individuals ought to approach ethical decisions with a sense of humility and introspection, recognising the inherent ambiguity and doing their best to act with integrity.

5. **Nature, Beauty, and Art:**

- **Concept:** Despite the weighty themes of absurdity and revolt, Camus also emphasises the role of nature, beauty, and art in human life. These elements can offer solace and moments of transcendence.
- **Implication:** In the face of the absurd, moments of beauty, whether in nature or art, provide brief respites and glimpses of meaning.
- **Ought:** Camus suggests that one ought to seek out and appreciate these moments, allowing them to enrich the human experience and offer a counterpoint to the inherent absurdity of life.

Camus' philosophy, rooted in his personal experiences and the tumultuous events of his time, offers a profound exploration of the human condition. While he paints a picture of a universe indifferent to human desires, he also provides a roadmap for

finding personal meaning, agency, and beauty within that vast expanse of indifference. The "oughts" of his philosophy guide individuals on how to live authentically and passionately, even in the shadow of the absurd.